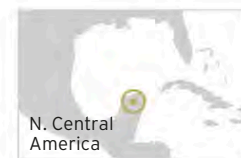


Chichén Itzá

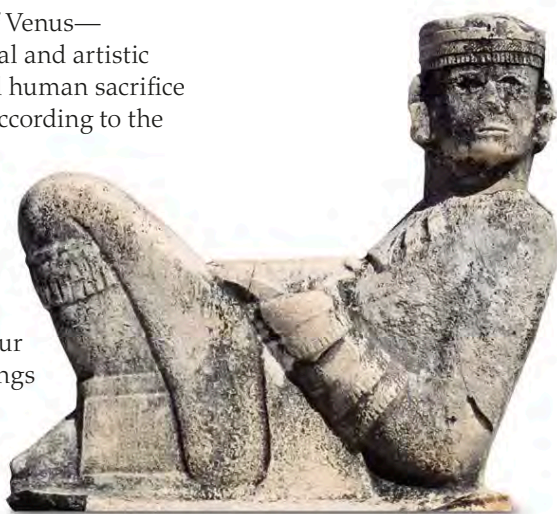
The last of the great Maya city-states, whose monuments include masterpieces of Mesoamerican architecture



The largest Maya city in southeastern Mexico, Chichén Itzá rose to prominence in the 9th century and fell into decline in the early 13th century. This remarkable World Heritage Site of around 4 square miles (10 square km) includes pyramids, temples, cenotes (sink holes), a ball court, and an astronomical observatory to chart the movements of Venus—indicating the civilization's rich spiritual and artistic life. Warfare, torture, bloodletting, and human sacrifice were highly significant for the Maya, according to the murals, stelae, and vessels upon which these sacred practices are depicted.

Central structure

The El Castillo pyramid towers above the city's main plaza. It has a combined total of 364 steps on its four sides; the step on the top platform brings the total to 365—the number of days in a solar year. Each stairway faces one of the four cardinal directions of the compass.

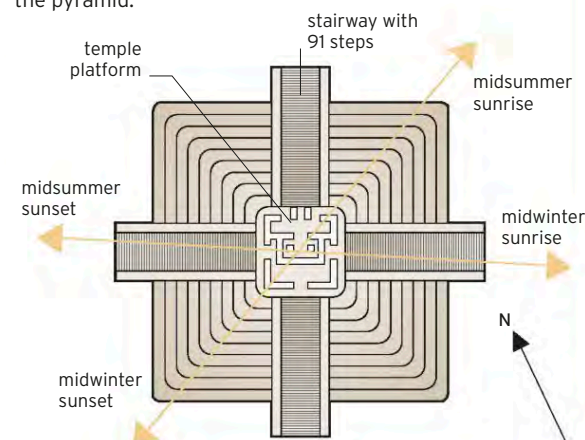


▽ CHAC-MOOL

At the entrance to the Temple of the Warriors is a statue of the rain god Chac-mool. He holds a receptacle that is thought to be for the hearts of human sacrifices.

SOLAR ALIGNMENT

The Maya worshipped the Sun and laid out the El Castillo pyramid to align with solstices. In addition, at the spring and fall equinoxes, the Sun casts a series of shadows against the northwest balustrade, creating an optical illusion of their feathered serpent deity crawling down the pyramid.



Copán

A major Maya city that provides a greater understanding of the complex civilization



Developed between the 5th and 9th centuries CE, the Maya city of Copán, Central America, is considered to be one of the civilization's major cities. The World Heritage Site is of particular interest to scholars for the expression of Maya cosmology evident in the city's design and architecture and its various sculptures and carvings.

Astronomical inspiration

Many of the sculptures and carvings were constructed during the reign of Copán's most famous ruler, King 18 Rabbit, to reflect the patterns of the cosmos and the

movement of the stars and planets, all of which helped the Maya to plan and regulate their lives. A major building in this respect is the magnificent Temple 22, conceived as a gateway to the underworld. It has numerous fascinating astronomical references, including a two-headed serpent representing the Milky Way, which symbolized the cosmic axis for the Maya. Copán's Temple of the Hieroglyphic Stairway is so called because it is beautifully carved with symbols, or glyphs, that relay the city's history. It was commissioned by King Smoke Shell and dedicated in 749 CE. Copán was abandoned in around 1200 CE. Restoration started in the 1930s and 1940s. In the mid-1970s, considerable advances were made in understanding the city's history by deciphering various hieroglyphs throughout the site.

◁ ELABORATE CARVING

Stela N is located in front of Temple 11, south of the Court of the Hieroglyphic Stairway. The figure on it wears a headdress, and glyphs are carved on its side.